policemen can’t find an object reported lost or stolen, they fully compensate the owner for it. Razzaq witnesses this personally. ‘Several slaves that my companions had bought ran away,’ he writes, and the policemen, after a futile search ‘in the quarter where the poor lived’, paid the fair price for each slave to the owners.

Razzaq also attended the Mahanavami festival at Vijayanagar, when a grand annual celebration was held in the royal centre for many days. He describes decorated multi-storeyed pavilions raised at the festival grounds, where mostly young female singers, dancers and reciters perform ‘in an astonishingly enchanting manner’. Elephants perform circus tricks. Generous rewards are given. All the chiefs and governors of the realm are present, with their ‘elephants roaring and raging like mountains and thunderclouds, adorned with weaponry and embellished with howdahs, with acrobats and pyrotechnists, and on the elephants’ heads, trunks and ears amazing pictures and strange designs painted in cinnabar and other [colours]’.

Soon after leaving the city for Calicut, Razzaq heard of a shocking assassination attempt on the king by his own brother. A festival had been organized and amid the sound of drums, the king, along with his other brothers, generals and ministers had been lured into traps and stabbed. But the injured king had somehow survived and regained control. Retribution followed: ‘All those who had in any way aided in the conspiracy were put to death. Men in great numbers were slain, flayed, burnt alive, and their families entirely executed. The man who had brought the letters of invitation [to the festival] was put to the last degree of torture.’

Indeed, the threat of assassination or usurpation and the need to pre-emptively strike were occupational hazards for a king—‘five assassinations and four usurpations’ occurred in Vijayanagar’s Sangama Dynasty alone.[14] Paranoia was commonplace. According to Fernao Nuniz, Virupaksha Raya (1465–85) had summoned one of his regional governors and had him put to death solely because in his dream the governor had entered his room to kill him.

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